

Top 5 Open Source Alternatives to Microsoft Office

Office suites have become common organisational and productivity tools. While Microsoft Office is the most popular suite today, there is a growing demand for more affordable alternatives. Numerous open source office suites have hit the market. Here is a selection of the top five that users can explore and use.



For the past several years, Microsoft Office has remained the leader in office productivity software offering integrated applications for word processing, spreadsheets, presentations, database management, email handling and above all, desktop publishing. An office suite is a mandatory part of any operating system's ecosystem. It is difficult to imagine a desktop operating system without office software. Windows has the Microsoft Office suite, which now dominates even the Mac market with Office for Mac. But for the Linux operating system, there are many choices available.

Some of the open source or free alternatives are even better than Microsoft Office when it comes to minimising costs and their capability to work with office files. However, all office suites are not the same and each has some limitation or the other. One also needs to bear in mind that the formatting of one file type can be saved in different ways for different programs. This can cause problems when sharing files with those using different software. Therefore, it's important to ensure that the

formatting is retained accurately. On top of that, you also need to ask which types of office software you actually need. Most packages offer documents and spreadsheets as standard, but some providers may not provide database or presentation software in a bundle. So it's important to check what you need and evaluate this against what providers will actually supply.

Here, we'll list the best open source office software alternatives to Microsoft Office for both home and business users.

1. OpenOffice

On July 19, 2000, at OSCON, Sun Microsystems announced it would make the source code of StarOffice available for download. The intention was to build an open source development community around the software, and provide a free and open alternative to Microsoft Office. The new project was known as OpenOffice.org and the code was released as open source on October 13, 2000. OpenOffice.org became the standard office suite on Linux and spawned many derivative versions. It quickly became a competitor